

Alcohol

Alcohol is a legal, socially acceptable drug. For many people, drinking alcohol is a pleasant experience, usually with friends or family. However, as with any drug, there are risks, so it's important to do so responsibly.

What is alcohol?

Alcohol is created by a chemical process called fermentation, which breaks down the sugars found in fruits, vegetables, or grains. Alcoholic beverages include beer, wine, and spirits. In moderate amounts, it reduces anxiety and social inhibition, and tends to make people feel more relaxed.

Most countries have an age restriction on when people can buy or drink alcohol. This is because the effects of alcohol can be more harmful for children and teens than they are for adults, as their brains are still developing.



SEE ALSO

◀ 18–19 Thinking independently

◀ 148–149 Safer streets

Building trust 176–177 ▶

Peer pressure 192–193 ▶

TEEN HINTS

Deciding to drink

Don't feel under pressure to drink alcohol because your friends are, or because it seems like everyone on TV or on social media is doing it.

Alcohol is not the solution if you're feeling anxious or worried about something.

◀ Party time

Some people enjoy having a drink when celebrating a special occasion.

Intoxication

In low doses, alcohol encourages feelings of sociability and talkativeness. However, binge drinking—drinking a large amount in a short time period—can lead to intoxication, or drunkenness. Drunkenness happens when the liver is unable to remove the alcohol and its toxins from the body quickly enough to keep up with consumption, causing the level of alcohol in the blood to rise quickly.

It's usually possible to tell if a person is drunk—their speech may slur, their balance may become impaired, they may seem more clumsy, and their skin may redden. Alcohol also affects a person's ability to form new memories, and to make decisions and judgments, making them more likely to take risks or engage in dangerous behavior.



◀ Being drunk

Some people get drunk more easily than others. As drinking alcohol can compromise a person's ability to make judgments, it's important to be in a safe space with trusted people.

GOOD TO KNOW

Hangovers

After a period of drinking, a person is likely to experience some unpleasant side effects, collectively known as a hangover. Scientists aren't sure exactly what causes hangovers. The toxins that alcohol leaves in the bloodstream, lowered levels of vitamins and minerals in the body, and the fact that alcohol causes dehydration are all contributing factors. It's not possible to cure a hangover, but drinking lots of water and taking painkillers can ease the symptoms. Even if you take these steps, a hangover can last for up to 24 hours and have several symptoms, including:

- a headache and muscle aches
- a dry mouth and a sensation of thirst
- nausea, vomiting, and stomach pain
- low mood and anxiety
- sensitivity to light and sound